# Seventy Times *Seven*

*...if he listens to you, you have won your brother.*

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 18:15-35 in the LSB | 29:59 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: The Hardest Words of Jesus (That Churches Ignore). Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND (ADDED) · DEBATED · LSB TEXT · ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

## Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 18:15-35. If your brother sins, show him his fault privately; then with one or two more; then tell the church; and if he refuses even the church, let him be as the Gentile and tax collector. What you bind and loose on earth shall have been bound and loosed in heaven; where two or three gather in Jesus' name, He is there. Peter asks whether forgiving seven times is enough; Jesus answers with the parable of the slave forgiven an enormous debt who would not forgive a small one.
- Binding and loosing is the language of halakha, the rabbis' work of applying God's commands to everyday life. In context, Jesus gives His community authority to deal with sin where Scripture gives no detailed instruction, and promises to agree with them.
- The steps are not new: they echo Leviticus 19:17, just before 'love your neighbor as yourself,' and the two or three witnesses of Deuteronomy 19:15. Jesus was not introducing new concepts but correctly interpreting God's word.
- Peter likely knew a rabbinic limit of three times and stretched to seven. Jesus answers with the number of Lamech's boast in Genesis 4:24: as revenge was a way of life for Lamech, radical forgiveness must be a way of life for the church. Peter heard discipline; Jesus meant reconciliation.
- The lesson: the discipline that Jesus commands for His church must be saturated in radical forgiveness, because

> *"The discipline that Jesus commands for His church must be saturated in radical forgiveness.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"Just as revenge was a way of life for Lamech, so must radical forgiveness be a way of life for all of you in the church.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

the goal of discipline is reconciliation. Excommunication must leave the door open; forgiveness keeps it open.

### Hear the number

When Jesus answers 'seventy times seven,' the teacher asks: is there a seventy-seven in the Old Testament? There is, in Lamech's song of revenge. A number can be a remez, a hint that brings a whole story with it.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB.

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

## Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 18:15-35 and turns to Leviticus 19, Deuteronomy 19, Matthew 5 and 6, and Genesis 4. Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

**Matthew 18:15-35**
Read in full: the steps of discipline, Peter's question, and the unforgiving slave.

**Leviticus 19:17-18**
Reprove your neighbor; love your neighbor.

**Deuteronomy 19:15**
Two or three witnesses.

**Matthew 16:19**
Binding and loosing given to Peter.

**Matthew 6:14-15**
Forgive, and your Father will forgive you.

**Matthew 5:17**
Not to abolish but to fulfill.

**Deuteronomy 18:15-18**
A prophet like Moses.

**Genesis 4:17-24**
Cain's line and Lamech's boast.

**Luke 17:3-4**
Seven times a day.

**John 17:20-23**
That they may be one.

**Matthew 19:1-12**
Coming next: Jesus on divorce.

### Key verses in the LSB

“Now if your brother sins, go and show him his fault, between you and him alone; if he listens to

“For where two or three have gathered together in My name, I am there in their midst.”

you, you have won your brother.”

Matthew 18:15 (LSB)

Matthew 18:20 (LSB)

“Jesus *said to him, “I do not say to you, up to seven times, but up to seventy times seven.”

Matthew 18:22 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

# You have won your brother

Private, then witnesses, then the church; binding and loosing.



MATTHEW 18:15; LEVITICUS 19:17

## Between you and him alone

JESUS · MATTHEW 18:15

““Now if your brother sins, go and show him his fault, between you and him alone; if he listens to you, you have won your brother.”

TORAH · LEVITICUS 19:17

“‘You shall not hate your brother in your heart; you may surely reprove your neighbor, and so not bear sin because of him.”

FROM THE VIDEO When Jesus says this, the disciples are meant to think of Leviticus 19:17, which comes just before the second part of the greatest commandment, 'you shall love your neighbor as yourself' (Leviticus 19:18). Leviticus 19:18

FROM THE VIDEO Confronting a brother privately is loving him as we love ourselves. It is the way we would want to be approached: not publicly in order to shame us, but privately in order to restore us.

◆ Factbook: Law of Moses ◆ Factbook: Golden rule



MATTHEW 18:16; DEUTERONOMY 19:15

## Two or three witnesses

JESUS · MATTHEW 18:16

“But if he does not listen to you, take one or two more with you, so that by the mouth of two or three witnesses every fact may be confirmed.”

TORAH · DEUTERONOMY 19:15

““A single witness shall not rise up against a man on account of any iniquity or any sin which he has committed; at the mouth of two or three witnesses a matter shall be established.”

FROM THE VIDEO The disciples should have remembered Deuteronomy 19:15. Jesus was not introducing new concepts for His people; He was correctly interpreting God's word.

FROM THE VIDEO This is partly why He said He came not to abolish the Law or the Prophets but to fulfill (Matthew 5:17). The video takes 'abolish' and 'fulfill' as idioms for misinterpreting and properly interpreting. Matthew 5:17

◆ Factbook: Book of Deuteronomy ◆ Factbook: Moses

MATTHEW 18:18-20; 16:19

### Bind and loose

🔑 **MATTHEW 18:18 (LSB)** HALAKHA

“Truly I say to you, whatever you bind on earth shall have been bound in heaven; and whatever you loose on earth shall have been loosed in heaven.”

**FROM THE VIDEO** Rabbis were constantly asked to interpret commands. God says no work on the Sabbath, but does not define work, so leaders would bind (prohibit) some activities and loose (permit) others.

**FROM THE VIDEO** Here the context is dealing with sin in the kingdom community. God provides authoritative liberty to walk out His commands where His word gives no clear instruction, and 'where two or three have gathered together in My name' He agrees (Matthew 18:20). Matthew 18:20

◆ Factbook: Binding and loosing ◆ Factbook: Halakha ◆ Factbook: Keys of the kingdom

MATTHEW 18:17

### As the Gentile and the tax collector

🚪 **MATTHEW 18:17 (LSB)** DOOR OPEN

“And if he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if he refuses to listen even to the church, let him be to you as the Gentile and the tax collector.”

**FROM THE VIDEO** Jesus means: excommunicate the sinner who refuses to hear and obey the church's correction. Disciplining unrepentant sinners is a must; sin left unchecked will undo the community from the inside out.

**FROM THE VIDEO** But excommunication is meant as a deterrent, not the offender's last opportunity. The door must stay open for someone to return with a repentant heart.

**BACKGROUND** Jesus Himself welcomed Gentiles and tax collectors; Matthew was one (9:9-10). Matthew 9:9-10

◆ Factbook: Church ◆ Factbook: Gentiles ◆ Factbook: Tax collector

> *“Not publicly in order to shame us, but privately in order to restore us.*
>
> From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

# Seventy times seven

Peter's limit and Lamech's song.

MATTHEW 18:21

### Up to seven times?

7️⃣ **MATTHEW 18:21 (LSB)** PETER'S LIMIT

“Then Peter came and said to Him, “Lord, how often shall my brother sin against me and I forgive him? Up to seven times?””

FROM THE VIDEO Peter is weighing excommunication against what Jesus said in Matthew 6:14-15: if you do not forgive, your Father will not forgive you. If the church can remove someone, when may an individual? **Matthew 6:14-15**

FROM THE VIDEO He likely knew the rabbinic expectation of forgiving three times, so he reaches further. But he is looking for a demarcation line.



GENESIS 4:23-24

## Lamech's song

🗡 **GENESIS 4:23-24 (LSB)**

REMEZ

“And Lamech said to his wives, / “Adah and Zillah, / Hear my voice, / You wives of Lamech, / Give ear to my word, / For I have killed a man for striking me; / And a boy for wounding me; / If Cain is avenged sevenfold, / Then Lamech seventy-sevenfold.””

FROM THE VIDEO Lamech, a descendant of Cain, lives his life marked by Cain's sin. His two-line poem, often called the Song of the Sword, is a boast: revenge is a way of life for him, next-level revenge.

FROM THE VIDEO If someone wounds him, he kills that man on the spot. This is horrific to brag about.



MATTHEW 18:22

## Seventy times seven

LAMECH · **GENESIS 4:24**

“If Cain is avenged sevenfold, / Then Lamech seventy-sevenfold.””

JESUS · **MATTHEW 18:22**

“Jesus *said to him, “I do not say to you, up to seven times, but up to seventy times seven.”

FROM THE VIDEO Jesus takes Lamech's number and fills it with new meaning: just as revenge was a way of life for Lamech, so must radical forgiveness be a way of life in the church.

BACKGROUND The Greek can mean seventy-seven times or seventy times seven; the Greek Old Testament uses the same phrase in Genesis 4:24. Either way the point is no limit.

◆ Factbook: Septuagint



MATTHEW 18:15-22

## Peter heard discipline

FROM THE VIDEO The disciples heard the teaching on reconciliation but latched on to the discipline part, as if it were for purging troublemakers. Jesus was thinking about reconciliation, so brothers and sisters stay aligned with God's word and mission.

FROM THE VIDEO There may be a hint of Lamech in Peter's attitude: if they go out the door, good riddance. That is not Jesus' heart.

◆ Factbook: Peter (Simon Peter)



*Lamech and his two wives*

Lamech and his two wives, engraving, 1583. Rijksmuseum via Wikimedia Commons, CC0

> *Just as revenge was a way of life for Lamech, so must radical forgiveness be a way of life for all of you in the church.*
>
> From the video

05 · FROM THE VIDEO · BACKGROUND · LSB TEXT

# The unforgiving slave

Ten thousand talents, one hundred denarii, and mercy from the heart.

MATTHEW 18:23-27

## Ten thousand talents

MATTHEW 18:24 (LSB)

UNPAYABLE

“When he had begun to settle them, one who owed him ten thousand talents was brought to him.”

BACKGROUND A talent was a huge sum, roughly six thousand denarii, and ten thousand was the largest Greek number word. The debt is meant to be unpayable, yet 'feeling compassion' the lord forgave it all (18:27). Matthew 18:27

◆ Factbook: Compassion

MATTHEW 18:28-30

## One hundred denarii

MATTHEW 18:28 (LSB)

CONTRAST

“But that slave went out and found one of his fellow slaves who owed him one hundred denarii; and he seized him and began to choke him, saying, ‘Pay back what you owe.’”

BACKGROUND A denarius was about a day's wage (20:2). The fellow slave uses the same plea, 'Have patience with me and I will repay you' (18:29), and is thrown into prison. Matthew 20:2 Matthew 18:29

MATTHEW 18:33-35; 6:12

## Should you not also have had mercy?

THE LORD · MATTHEW 18:33

“Should you not also have had mercy on your fellow slave, in the same way that I had mercy on you?”’

THE LORD'S PRAYER · MATTHEW 6:12

“And forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors.”

FROM THE VIDEO What God calls us to is radical forgiveness and radical mercy as a way of life. Go back and look at the Beatitudes and the Sermon on the Mount.

BACKGROUND Jesus closes, 'if each of you does not forgive his brother from your hearts' (18:35). Matthew 18:35

◆ Factbook: Mercy ◆ Factbook: Forgiveness ◆ Factbook: Prayer

THE LESSON

## Saturated in radical forgiveness

FROM THE VIDEO The discipline Jesus commands must be saturated in radical forgiveness, because the goal of discipline is reconciliation, whether today, tomorrow or some point in the future.

FROM THE VIDEO Just because reconciliation is not possible with some folks in the moment, it does not mean forgiveness should not be extended. Forgiveness leaves the door open; there can be no expiration date on it.

FROM THE VIDEO If we are going to march forward together in unity (John 17), reconciliation must be one of the fundamental components of our community. John 17:21



*Have patience with me*

Claude Vignon, Parable of the Unforgiving Servant, 1629. Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *“Forgiveness leaves the door open to reconciliation.*

From the video

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# Who's who in 18:15-35

What the video says, then a short background note.

### Simon Peter

VIDEO Asks whether seven times is enough; often the spokesman for the disciples.

BACKGROUND Later he writes, 'love covers a multitude of sins' (1 Peter 4:8).

1 Peter 4:8 ◆ Peter (Simon Peter)

### Lamech

VIDEO Cain's descendant who boasts of seventy-sevenfold revenge.

BACKGROUND Fifth from Cain; the first man in Scripture with two wives (Genesis 4:19).

Genesis 4:19 ◆ Lamech

### Adah and Zillah

VIDEO Lamech's wives, who hear his song.

BACKGROUND Mothers of Jabal, Jubal and Tubal-cain (Genesis 4:20-22).

Genesis 4:20-22 ◆ Lamech

### The forgiven slave

VIDEO In Jesus' parable, forgiven a vast debt but unwilling to forgive a small one.

BACKGROUND His lord hands him over 'until he should repay all' (18:34).

Matthew 18:34

### Cain

VIDEO Lamech's ancestor, avenged sevenfold.

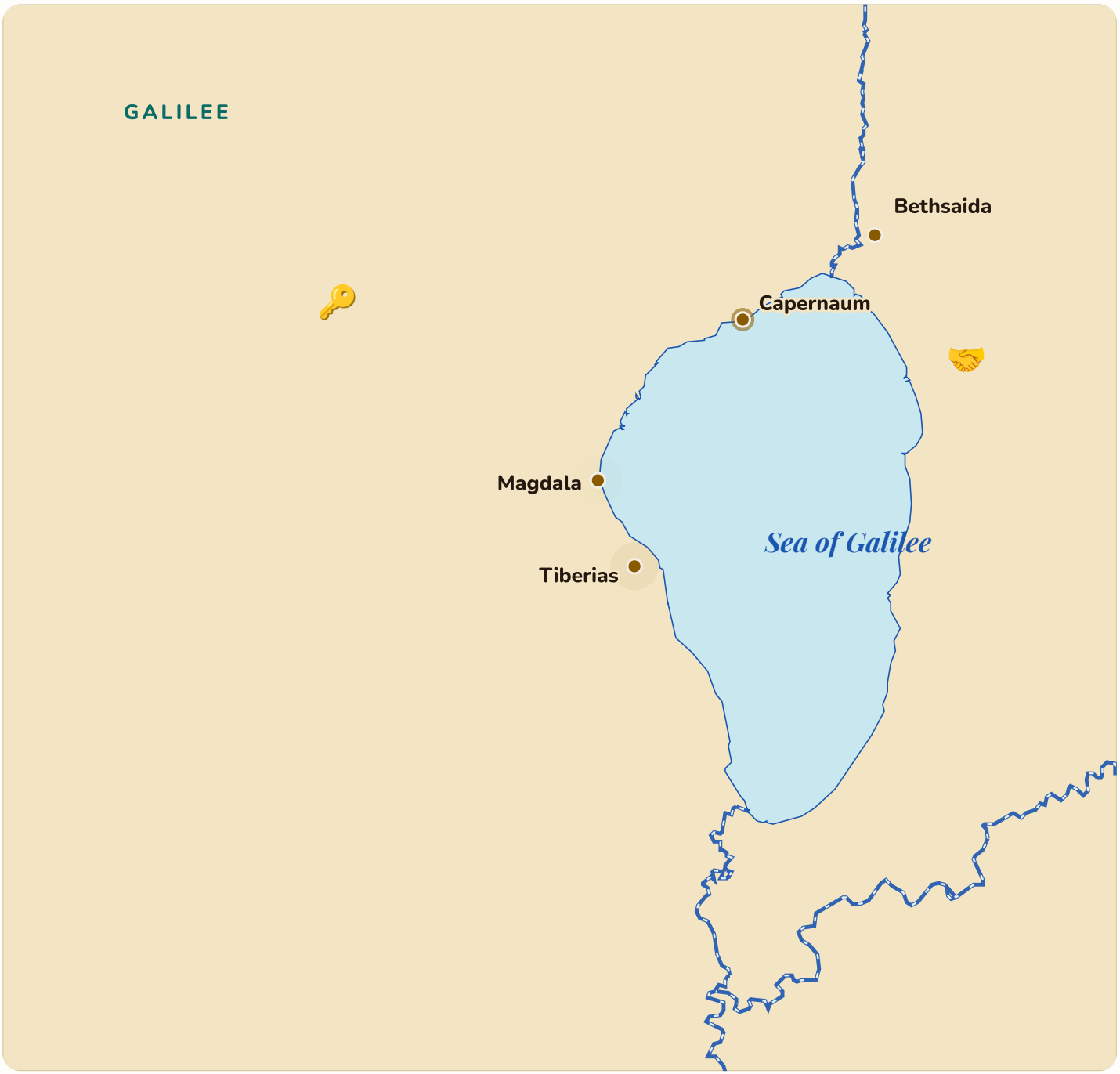
BACKGROUND God set a sign on him so no one would kill him (Genesis 4:15).

Genesis 4:15 ◆ Cain

07 · BACKGROUND

# Still in Galilee

Gold pins are background places; the video names no place here.




● Named in the video ● Background

Positions from known sites; Bethsaida's exact site is debated. The video names no place; this is the last setting before Jesus leaves Galilee. Lake outline and Jordan River: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).

### Capernaum BACKGROUND

The teaching continues in the house (Mark 9:33); Jesus leaves Galilee next (19:1).

◆ Factbook: Capernaum

### Bethsaida BACKGROUND

Peter's hometown (John 1:44).

◆ Factbook: Bethsaida

### Magdala BACKGROUND

A fishing town on the west shore.

◆ Factbook: Magdala

### Tiberias BACKGROUND

Herod Antipas' capital on the lake.

◆ Factbook: Tiberias

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# Key terms

### Halakha

VIDEO

Jewish legal interpretation: how to walk out God's commands in everyday life. The captions write 'halaka' and 'hahikic.'

◆ Factbook: Halakha

### Binding and loosing

VIDEO

Prohibiting and permitting; here, the church's authority in dealing with sin.

◆ Factbook: Binding and loosing

### Excommunication

VIDEO

Removing an unrepentant member from the community, with the door left open to return.

◆ Factbook: Church ◆ Factbook: Excommunication

### Song of the Sword

VIDEO

A common name for Lamech's boast in Genesis 4:23-24.

◆ Factbook: Lex talionis ◆ Factbook: Lamech

### Talent

BACKGROUND

A very large unit of money, about six thousand denarii.

◆ Factbook: Mammon ◆ Factbook: Talent

### Denarius

BACKGROUND

A Roman silver coin, about a day's wage for a laborer (Matthew 20:2).

◆ Factbook: Denarius

09 · BACKGROUND

# Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

### ἐλέγχω

***elenchō*** G1651

To show someone his fault, convict, reprove.

Greek · Matt 18:15

### κερδαίνω

***kerdainō*** G2770

To gain, win.

Greek · Matt 18:15

### ἐκκλησία

***ekklēsia*** G1577

### δέω

***deō*** G1210

Assembly, church; only here and 16:18 in the Gospels.
Greek · Matt 18:17

◆ Factbook: Church

To bind; in rabbinic usage, to forbid.
Greek · Matt 18:18

◆ Factbook: Binding and loosing

## λύω

***lyō*** G3089

To loose; in rabbinic usage, to permit.
Greek · Matt 18:18

◆ Factbook: Binding and loosing

## ἑβδομηκοντάκις

***hebdomēkontakis*** G1441

Seventy times. Look up: BDAG, ἑβδομηκοντάκις.
Greek · Matt 18:22

## ἀφίημι

***aphiēmi*** G863

To release, forgive, let go.
Greek · Matt 18:21, 27

◆ Factbook: Forgiveness

## τάλαντον

***talanton*** G5007

Talent, a large weight of silver.
Greek · Matt 18:24

◆ Factbook: Talent

## ἐλεέω

***eleeō*** G1653

To have mercy.
Greek · Matt 18:33

◆ Factbook: Mercy

## יָכַח

***yakach*** H3198

To reprove, rebuke, set right. Look up: BDB or HALOT, יכח.
Hebrew · Lev 19:17

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# Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

### Binding and loosing in the rabbis

In rabbinic literature 'bind' and 'loose' are standard terms for forbidding and permitting. Jesus gave the same authority to Peter (16:19) and here to the community, in the setting of sin and discipline.

### The 'three times' rule

The closest written source is a saying in the Babylonian Talmud: 'When a person commits a transgression the first time, he is forgiven; a second time, he is forgiven; a third time, he is forgiven; but the fourth time, he is not forgiven' (Talmud Yoma 86b). It cites Amos 2:6 and speaks of God's forgiveness.

### Debt and debt slavery

Selling a debtor with his family (18:25) reflects ancient practice, which the Torah limited for Israelites (Leviticus 25:39-43). A king's official owing ten thousand talents would be beyond any repayment.

## SOURCED Early witnesses

> *He did not say, You have a sufficient revenge, but, You have gained your brother, to show that there is a common loss from the enmity.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 60, on 18:15. Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, series 1, vol. 10 (public domain).

> *not setting a number here, but what is infinite and perpetual and forever.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 61, on 18:22. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

> *Two things therefore does He here require, both to condemn ourselves for our sins, and to forgive others*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 61, on 18:35. NPNF 1.10 (public domain).

## DEBATED Where scholars differ

### Seventy-seven or seventy times seven?

The Greek hebdomēkontakis hepta can mean 77 (as in the Greek of Genesis 4:24) or 490. The LSB has 'seventy times seven'; the video reads 77. Both point beyond counting.

### Abolish and fulfill as idioms

The video takes 'abolish' and 'fulfill' (5:17) as rabbinic idioms for misinterpreting and correctly interpreting the Law. Some scholars hold this view; others read 'fulfill' as bringing the Law and Prophets to their goal in Jesus.

### Who binds and looses?

In 16:19 the words are spoken to Peter, in 18:18 to the disciples ('you' plural). Traditions differ on how the authority passes to church leaders or the whole congregation.

## CAREFUL READING Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- The video reads 'seventy-seven times' in 18:22; the LSB has 'up to seventy times seven.' The Greek allows either.
- The video's text of 18:15 says 'sins against you'; the LSB has 'if your brother sins,' because many early manuscripts lack 'against you.'
- The rabbinic 'three times' limit is stated without a source. The closest text, Talmud Yoma 86b, is about God forgiving repeated transgression, not forgiving a brother.
- Reading 'abolish' and 'fulfill' as Hebrew idioms for interpretation is one scholarly view, not a settled one.
- The captions write 'hahikic,' 'hakic' and 'halaka' for halakha and halakhic, 'rebbitic' and 'rabbitic' for rabbinic, 'Kane' for Cain, 'Ada and Zilla' for Adah and Zillah, and 'biatitudes' for Beatitudes.

11 · BACKGROUND

# From Lamech to the Talmud

Coral dots mark what Matthew 18:15-35 echoes or this episode covers. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

PRIMEVAL HISTORY DEBATED
**Lamech's song: seventy-sevenfold revenge**
Genesis 4:23-24 *Remez: 18:22*

C. 1400 BC DEBATED
**Reprove your neighbor; two or three witnesses**
Leviticus 19:17

C. AD 28 DEBATED
**'Forgive us our debts' in the Sermon on the Mount**
Matthew 6:12

C. AD 29 DEBATED
**Discipline, forgiveness and the unforgiving slave**
Matthew 18:15-35 *This episode*

C. AD 390
**Chrysostom: 'what is infinite and perpetual'**
Matthew 18:22

C. AD 500 DEBATED
**The Babylonian Talmud records the 'three times' saying**
Amos 2:6

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# Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Leviticus 19:17-18
Reprove your neighbor

Deuteronomy 19:15
Two or three witnesses

ADDED

ADDED

Genesis 4:23-24
Lamech's boast
ADDED

Matthew 6:14-15
Forgive and be forgiven
ADDED

Galatians 6:1
Restore in a spirit of gentleness
ADDED

Ephesians 4:32
Graciously forgiving each other
ADDED

Colossians 3:13
Just as the Lord forgave you
ADDED

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# Reflection and discussion

0 of 6 questions marked done on this device.

1 ☐ Why does Jesus start with a private conversation rather than a public one?

2 ☐ How does Leviticus 19:17-18 connect correcting someone with loving them?

3 ☐ What did Peter's question reveal about how he heard Jesus' teaching?

4 ☐ How does Lamech's song change the way you hear 'seventy times seven'?

5 ☐ Is there someone for whom you have put an expiration date on forgiveness?

6 ☐ How can a church practice discipline and still keep the door open?

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# Application

FROM THE VIDEO

The lesson, stated plainly: the discipline that Jesus commands for His church must be saturated in radical

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

before you speak to anyone else about a hurt, ask whether you have gone to the person

forgiveness, because the goal of discipline is reconciliation. Forgiveness and mercy are in short supply in many churches; hot takes, rage-baiting and cancelling people have crept in from the culture, and that can naturally follow from the spirit behind Peter's question. The teacher shares a pastoral story of a colleague who would not talk with hurting former members again, and warns that many Christians believe they are being righteous in their unwillingness to reconcile. Saturate your interactions with radical forgiveness and radical mercy, especially when dealing with someone else's sin.

'between you and him alone' (18:15). Pray Matthew 6:12 slowly, naming one person.

> *"The discipline that Jesus commands for His church must be saturated in radical forgiveness.*
>
> From the video

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# Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ Moses ◆ Jordan River ◆ Repentance ◆ Galilee ◆ Capernaum
◆ Book of Deuteronomy ◆ John Chrysostom ◆ The Beatitudes ◆ Bethsaida ◆ Disciples ◆ Divorce
◆ Fishing ◆ Gentiles ◆ Herod Antipas ◆ Law of Moses ◆ Magdala ◆ Mercy ◆ Prayer
◆ The Prophets (books) ◆ Sea of Galilee ◆ Sermon on the Mount ◆ Peter (Simon Peter)
◆ Babylonian Talmud ◆ Tax collector ◆ Tiberias ◆ Forgiveness ◆ Golden rule ◆ Halakha
◆ Septuagint ◆ Sinner ◆ Compassion ◆ Parable ◆ Rabbi ◆ Sabbath ◆ Binding and loosing
◆ Church ◆ Keys of the kingdom ◆ Cain ◆ Denarius ◆ Excommunication ◆ Lamech ◆ Talent

Source: the video's auto-generated YouTube captions, read in full. Scripture quotations are from the Legacy Standard Bible, copyright 2021 by The Lockman Foundation. All rights reserved. Chrysostom: Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (public domain). Talmud Yoma: Sefaria, William Davidson Edition (CC BY-NC). Images: Wikimedia Commons (Claude Vignon, public domain; Rijksmuseum, CC0). Map data: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).